

R' Gedalia Schorr זצ"ל in Ohr Gedalyahu ties together פרשת שופטים and חודש אלול. He writes, in his inimitable style, that the Torah says: שְׁפָטִים וְשֹׁטְרִים תִּתֵּן לָהֶם בְּכָל שְׁעָרֶיךָ. It is brought down in the ספר יצירה that each and every opening of our physical body is called a שַׁעַר, a gate. So when the pasuk says שְׁפָטִים וְשֹׁטְרִים תִּתֵּן לָהֶם בְּכָל שְׁעָרֶיךָ, it means that we have to place judges and guardians at all of our gates, all of the openings of the body, so that no עבירה comes through any one of them. The mouth is the obvious example, whether it is לשון הרע, improper אכילה, or otherwise. A person has to use his head and שכל to control his לב. That is what שוטרים means. When he is not able to control himself, when things are not going his way, when he loses control, when he is unable to use his full capabilities to restrain himself - that is the time when the שוטרים come in. A person has the ability to be גובר on himself.

What R' Gedalia did very interestingly here is a new take on a pasuk which I've learned many times with my משפחה. That's what we say by קל ימי חיי (תהילים כ"ז:ד'): דוד המלך. What does קל ימי חיי mean by דוד המלך? קל ימי חיי is saying that in every situation, whether it's light, whether it's darkness חס ושלום, we have to uphold our concept of שְׁפָטִים וְשֹׁטְרִים. A major עבודה of חודש אלול is to remember our status as those who reside in בֵּית ה'. This requires constant effort throughout our lives, and should be reinforced at this time of the year.

By the way, which pasuk is כולל every other pasuk in the Torah? אֵת הַכֶּבֶשׂ אֶחָד תַּעֲשֶׂה בִבְקָר וְאֵת הַכֶּבֶשׂ הַשֵּׁנִי תַעֲשֶׂה בֵּין הָעֶרְבָּיִם (במדבר כ"ח:ד'). One of the פשטים of what this means is when we're on our way up and we're getting better, stronger, then we want to be able to serve Hashem. One of the ways of accomplishing that is by using our כוחות to be גובר on our יצר הרע. And on our way down, the second half of all of our lives, when we can't do what we used to, we should still be able to utilize our כוחות to serve Hashem in exactly the same way with the same התלהבות, with the same intensity, with the same success. So he has that here as קל ימי חיי. קל ימי חיי ties right in with that pasuk. If we're able to utilize our שכל and our hearts to do the רצון השם, and to put those שְׁפָטִים וְשֹׁטְרִים to proper use, then we can then be successful in our life's journey towards גדלות, towards שלמות, towards fulfilling הוא רצון's הקדוש ברוך הוא.

